Two-wheelers meet most household mobility needs and are increasingly used by gig workers and in shared mobility, says Anumita Roychowdhury, executive director, Centre for Science and Environment. "They will remain popular. You can't just wish them away," she adds. Electric scooters, meanwhile, are gaining ground with policy support, including Delhi's new EV policy. "We are setting up a wide public charging network. This will aid our fight against pollution as well as congestion," says Pankaj Kumar Singh, Delhi's transport minister.

The Price of Convenience

But the dependence on two-wheelers also comes at a human cost. In 2024, 81,780 two-wheeler users died in road accidents, accounting for 46.2 per cent of the 177,175 fatalities recorded that year, according to the ministry of road transport and highways. The popularity of motorised two-wheelers (MTWs) is partly explained by gaps in public transport, says Geetam Tiwari, professor emeritus at IIT Delhi's Transportation Research and Injury Prevention (TRIP) Centre. "An MTW is reliable, economical to use and provides door-to-door mobility. However, it comes with a very high risk of traffic crashes for the users as well as pedestrians. In India, 25 per cent of pedestrian deaths involve MTWs."

The survey also records significant reliance on non-motorised transport. Bicycles account for 10.7 per cent of qualifying work commutes and 15.8 per cent of student commutes to educational institutions, while walking accounts for 28.3 per cent of work trips. But the one-km minimum distance for inclusion means the survey misses almost 70 per cent of walking trips, notes Tiwari. "That would have provided the rationale for investment in pedestrian infrastructure," she says.



"We were taken aback by the large share of two-wheelers. We were perhaps not ready for the fact that public transport penetration is so very low"

— **R. GOPALAKRISHNAN,** *Divisional Railway Manager, Secunderabad, who was involved in designing the NHTS*

THE SHORTCOMINGS

- Low bus and mass-transit penetration; inadequate connectivity to stops
- Poor pedestrian facilities, unsafe road crossings and shrinking pedestrian spaces
- Subsidised parking and grade-separated corridors prioritise private vehicles

THE SOLUTIONS

- Improve bus infrastructure, fleets and reliability
- Invest in pedestrian infrastructure, safe crossings and connectivity to public transport stops
- Bring homes, workplaces and daily amenities within walking or cycling distance



"Our planning and investment continue to prioritise private vehicles over public transport. Their use is heavily subsidised with free or inexpensive parking"

— **GEETAM TIWARI,** *Professor Emeritus, IIT Delhi*

Rethinking the Journey

The average one-way commute to a fixed workplace is 25 minutes nationally and 27 minutes in urban India. But these averages do not capture the experience of commuters in big cities. "I feel lucky on the very rare days when I can reach home from work, or any place in the central part of the city, in less than an hour. And I'm counting Sundays too," says Martin Mathew, a 32-year-old marketing executive in Bengaluru, who travels some 15 km each way to work.

Transport experts say the problem lies partly in how cities are planned and public money spent. "Our planning and investment continue to prioritise private vehicles over public transport," says Tiwari. Their use is heavily subsidised through free or inexpensive parking and the addition of grade-separated, signal-free corridors, often at the expense of pedestrian spaces, she adds. Public transport users, on the other hand, face poor connectivity to stops, inadequate pedestrian infrastructure, unsafe road crossings and badly located bus and metro stations. Information about available services also remains poor. "One big disconnect is infrastructure development versus usage," says Amit Bhatt, managing director (India), International Council on Clean Transportation. Roychowdhury's prescription is simple: you cannot discourage two wheelers in this day and age, but you can incentivise public transport through "a strong, interconnected and easily accessible system of buses, metros and paratransit".

The challenge also extends to urban planning. "Our workplaces and our residences are not in proximity to each other, which they ought to be," says Jagan Shah, an urban development policy expert. Shah points to the "15-minute city" concept, developed by French-Colombian urbanist Carlos Moreno, which envisages neighbourhoods where everyday needs are accessible within a 15-minute walk or cycle ride. "So, then, it's not just about public transport, it's also about the way that we plan our neighbourhoods and our areas of economic activity." The goal is simple: bring everyday life closer home. ■